



Leading from the front: Sai Kishore led IDream Tiruppur Tamizhans to its maiden TNPL crown this year.

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breakthrough IPL season until this year, so every TNPL was another chance to prove myself. I had to keep making my case stronger. That mindset helped me stay relevant. If I wasn't getting enough opportunities in IPL, I treated TNPL or SMAT as the stage to showcase and upgrade my game.

And what changed this year after your successful IPL season?

It felt like a weight off my shoulders. I always believed I was good enough but hadn't had the chance to show it. After doing well this year, it was even more important to respect TNPL — because that's where I got my platform. If you play IPL and then return to TNPL without winning games, it doesn't make sense. I wanted to play with the

same intensity I'd bring to an IPL match, and that really helped me.

Has TNPL grown into a feeder system for State and IPL cricket, or is it still more of a local tournament?

It's definitely a feeder for State cricket and, for bowlers, even the IPL. TNPL grounds are smaller, wickets turn more, and yet it's still tough on bowlers. That's why even established IPL players sometimes struggle here. If the league could replicate IPL-level fast bowling, it would be an even stronger feeder to international cricket.

But we've already seen players like Sai Sudharsan, Tushar Raheja, and Ajith Ram make the jump. I myself debuted for Tamil Nadu because of TNPL. So yes, it has been a proper feeder system.

How does workload management actually work? Fans often wonder why a bowler is rested or rotated. What should they understand?

For T20s, my match load is around 24 balls. So, in training, I make sure I bowl about 45–50 balls in a session. That way, my body is ready to handle a full T20 match load.

For red-ball cricket, I scale up. I try to mirror a match schedule. If I expect to bowl 45–60 overs in a game, I spread that out across the week. For example: 25 overs one day, 10 the next, a rest day, then 20 the following day. By the end of the week, I've hit that target.

Do you plan this on your own or with support staff?

Initially, I never bothered. I was old-school — just bowl until you drop. But after a neck injury, I realised I needed structure.

Darren Veness, the Strength & Conditioning Coach at Gujarat Titans, really helped me understand the science behind it.

Now, I keep it simple. If my maximum in a match is 60 overs — 30 in each innings — that's my benchmark. If I hit that in training, I